

FOLLOW THE SMELL
(clockwise from left) Reed diffuser from SEVA Home; Eden perfume room spray from Decoaura; Zeph perfume room spray also from Decoaura

Picture this, golden light filtering through sheer linen, a quiet breeze and a home with zing of lemon, the coolness of mint or the soft comfort of jasmine in bloom. "Summer afternoon to me have always been the two most beautiful words in the English language," wrote Henry James, American-British author. It is a sentiment that resonates deeply as we retreat indoors to escape the sweltering heat.

As Indian homes become design-conscious and wellness-led, fragrance is emerging as a defining part of summer living. No longer just a finishing touch, scent is now an integral part of how we design, experience and emotionally connect with our spaces. This season, in particular, is seeing a shift towards 'quiet luxury' where fragrances are subtle, breathable and deeply intentional.

From Cosy to Crisp

The transition from winter to summer interiors is not just visual, it's olfactory. Heavy notes such as oud, amber and vanilla, which feel comforting in colder months, can quickly become overpowering in heat. "During summer, people tend to choose light, fresh and airy scents that help their homes feel cooler and more inviting," says Rajat Jain, co-founder and olfactory expert, Kimirica, a lifestyle brand rooted in thoughtful self-care. "The idea is to create a space that feels effortlessly welcoming rather than intensely scented," he says.

Lighter compositions such as citrus, green tea, marine accords and soft florals are now the go-to for homes that need to breathe. At the heart of this year's fragrance trends is a balance between freshness and grounding. "Summer 2026 is centred around clean minimalism with a sensory twist," notes Divyata Patil, founder of Decoaura, a toxin-free home fragrance brand.

Citrus scents such as mandarin and bergamot, aquatic accords and green notes such as tea and fig leaf are key, points out Patil. These are often layered with softer bases such as vetiver or musk, ensuring the scent doesn't evaporate too quickly in the heat. The result? Fragrances that feel like a coastal escape, light, sunlit and luxurious.

Global meets Indigenous

Indian consumers are increasingly embracing a hybrid fragrance identity that blends global trends with traditional notes. "There is a convergence of both. Vetiver, mogra and kewra are being

